New Atlanta Fed Community Advisory Council: Informing Economic Policy

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- Partners Update
- Publication
- Community and Economic Development
- Regional Economy

Key Points

- This fall, the Federal Reserve Bank of Atlanta welcomed 12 southeastern community leaders to join its inaugural Community Advisory Council (CAC).
- The Atlanta Fed's CAC will meet twice yearly to inform the Atlanta Fed's understanding of current economic conditions for monetary policy deliberations, the Community Perspectives section of the Beige Book, and priorities for research and engagement on issues related to community and economic development.
- Council members join several existing Atlanta Fed advisory councils made up of regional business leaders. This October's meeting coincided with a joint gathering of all District council members, providing an opportunity for cross-industry learning and network building.
- The CAC joins a network of community advisors sitting on councils at other regional Federal Reserve Banks, as well as a national CAC hosted by the Federal Reserve Board of Governors in Washington, DC.

In October 2026, the Federal Reserve Bank of Atlanta welcomed 12 southeastern community leaders to join its new Community Advisory Council (CAC). Council members represent diverse sectors engaged in consumer and community activities across all six states in the Sixth District. Each is a subject matter expert with extensive industry knowledge and active engagement with the region's low- and moderate-income communities. Members will serve on the council for terms of up to three years.

Community Advisory Council members. Left to right: Jannease Seastrunk, Kent Miller, Newton Sanon, Michael Williamson (back row). Mary Ellen Judah, Amelia Nickerson, Lamont Price, Stephen Barnes, Mari Kuraishi, Diane Standaert (front row). Not pictured: Carlos Enrique Alemán and Suganthi Simon.

Their insights will inform the Atlanta Fed's understanding of current economic conditions for monetary policy deliberations, the Community Perspectives section of the Beige Book, Community Reinvestment Act opportunities, and priorities for research and engagement on issues related to community and

economic development. These efforts support the Bank's broader goal of advancing economic mobility and resilience across the region.

"By listening to those on the front lines of community and economic development, the Fed gains a window into the real lives behind the statistics—discovering how individuals and families navigate challenges and seize new opportunities," according to Paula Tkac, an executive vice president and director of research at the Atlanta Fed.

The CAC will meet twice yearly to offer insights on labor market, inflation, access to financial services, and community development investment conditions in low- and moderate-income communities. These issues are relevant to many households across the region. Nationally and in the Sixth District, about two in five households are considered low- and moderate-income, defined as earning 80 percent or less of area median income.[1] This threshold is $94,250 per year for a family of four in the Atlanta metro area.[2]

"We're committed to delivering research, data tools, and events that position communities to tackle their challenges, seize opportunities, and build a thriving economy for all," said Karen Leone de Nie, vice president of Community and Economic Development at the Atlanta Fed. "Insights from experts doing the work inform and strengthen our ability to help them realize that vision."

The CAC joins several existing Atlanta Fed advisory councils made up of business leaders who collectively provide information about economic conditions across the District. The council's inaugural meeting coincided with a joint gathering of all advisory council members, providing an opportunity for cross-industry learning and network building. Together, these councils help the Atlanta Fed understand economic conditions from a range of perspectives. The Bank also synthesizes insights from roundtables, interviews, focus groups, and quantitative and qualitative data analysis to understand the economy from all vantage points—employers, investors, financial institutions, workers, jobseekers, and consumers.

Federal Reserve Bank of Atlanta Interim President and First Vice President Cheryl Venable addresses councilmembers at the joint advisory council convening.

The Atlanta Fed's CAC is also part of a network of community advisers at Reserve Banks across the country. In addition, the Federal Reserve's Board of Governors in Washington, DC, hosts a Community Advisory Council which provides feedback and advice to the Board on issues affecting consumers and communities at a national level.

Members of the Atlanta Fed Community Advisory Council, Fall 2026

Community Advisory Councilmember	Title	Organization	City
Carlos Enrique Alemán, PhD	Chief Executive Officer	Hispanic and Immigrant Center of Alabama (HICA)	Birmingham, AL
Stephen Barnes, PhD	Executive Director, Blanco Public Policy Center	University of Louisiana at Lafayette	Lafayette, LA
Mary Ellen Judah	Executive Director	Neighborhood Concepts, Inc.	Huntsville, AL
Mari Kuraishi	President	Jessie Ball duPont Fund	Jacksonville, FL
Kent Miller	Chief Executive Officer	Martha O'Bryan Center	Nashville, TN
Amelia Nickerson	Chief Executive Officer	First Step Staffing, Inc.	Atlanta, GA
Lamont Price	Innovation Director	Tennessee Department of Economic and Community Development	Nashville, TN
Newton Sanon	President and Chief Executive Officer	OIC of South Florida	Fort Lauderdale, FL
Jannease Seastrunk	Senior Vice President, Community Relations & CRA Officer	Red River Bank	Alexandria, LA
Suganthi Simon	Vice President, Global Philanthropy	JPMorgan Chase & Co.	Atlanta, GA
Diane Standaert	Senior Vice President, Policy and Advocacy	Hope Credit Union, Hope Enterprise Corporation, Hope Policy Institute	Jackson, MS
Michael Williamson	President and Chief Executive Officer	United Way of Southeast Louisiana	New Orleans, LA

For more information about the Atlanta Fed's CAC and related efforts, please reach out to julie.siwicki@atl.frb.org.

The views expressed here are those of the author and not necessarily those of the Federal Reserve Bank of Atlanta or the Federal Reserve System. Any remaining errors are the author's responsibility.

The Federal Reserve Bank of Atlanta's Community and Economic Development function supports the Central Bank's mandate of stable prices and maximum employment by helping improve the economic opportunity of low- and moderate-income (LMI) individuals and underserved places for a stronger economy for all Americans. Community development is one of the Federal Reserve's core functions and this responsibility is rooted in its mandates from Congress. Partners Update articles address community and economic development trends, issues, and events. Find more research, use data tools, and sign up for email updates at Community Economic and Development.

- [1] Grace Johnsen and Alvaro Sánchez, "How Many Households in the Southeast Are Low- to Moderate-Income?," Partners Update (Federal Reserve Bank of Atlanta, October 14, 2026).
- [2] "FY 2026 Income Limits Summary," Office of Policy Development and Research, US Department of Housing and Urban Development.

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